

Under a shell

You can spot tortoises or turtles because they carry their homes on their backs – these domes, called shells, are attached to their bodies.



Tortoise

Tortoise or turtle?

The main difference between these two reptiles is that tortoises live on land and turtles live in water.

Shell shapes

Shells are hard and protect the body. They come in many shapes.



Starred tortoise: their high domed shells are difficult to attack.



African red-necked turtle: flatter shells help turtles slip through water.



Red-footed tortoise: these tortoises have unusually long shells.



Turtles

Tortoises

Tortoises walk very slowly because of their heavy shells. They have short, stocky legs that support their weight.

They spend most of the day eating plants.

Turtles

Turtles live under water. They sometimes poke their heads out to breathe, but they can also breathe through their skin. Some can stay under the surface for weeks.

